Let's actively promote plant-based options and make them good

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. . . As opposed to (or in addition to)

1. saying meat is bad
2. saying “other people like plant-based options”
3. making them available without comment

Meaningfully reducing consumption of meat and animal products (MAP) is hard

- Last year I worked on a big meta-analytic review of interventions to get people to eat less MAP.
- We only looked at rigorous studies (RCTs with > 50 subjects that measured MAP consumption directly at least a day after treatment began)
- As of 12/2023, 35 papers met our criteria



Full Length Article

Meaningfully reducing consumption of meat and animal products is an unsolved problem: A meta-analysis

Seth Ariel Green [a], Benny Smith [b], Maya B. Mathur [a]

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What interventions have been tried?

- Almost everything tries to:
  - Tell people meat is bad (environmental/health/animal welfare)
  - Make plant-based options more salient (eye-level on menus)
  - Make animal-based options less convenient
  - Tell people that plant-based options are tasty and their peers like them
  - Exploit psychological tendencies, e.g., to conform or to stick to a plan they've made
- Overall, small & sparse effects

Table 1. Main findings.

Approach	N (Studies)	N (Estimates)	SMD	τ	95% CIs	p val
Overall	41	112	0.07	0.08	[0.02, 0.12]	0.007
Theory						
Choice Architecture	2	3	0.21	0	[-0.99, 1.42]	0.267
Psychology	9	12	0.11	0.03	[-0.03, 0.24]	0.092
Persuasion	25	77	0.07	0.09	[0.01, 0.13]	0.023
Persuasion & Psychology	11	20	0.11	0.19	[-0.06, 0.28]	0.189
Types of Persuasion						
Animal Welfare	16	65	0.03	0.04	[-0.02, 0.07]	0.189
Environment	16	29	0.09	0.12	[-0.02, 0.19]	0.095
Health	18	29	0.08	0.09	[-0.01, 0.17]	0.064

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What about adding new plant-based options to menus?

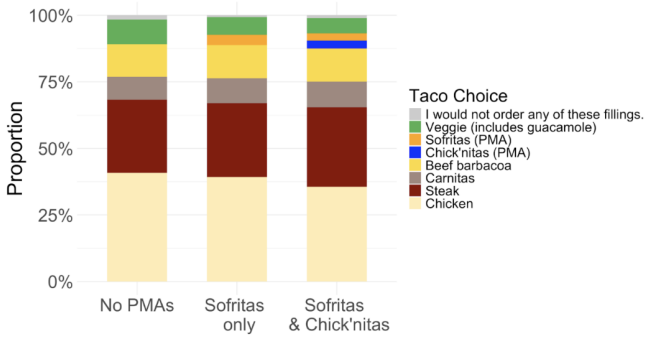
- We tried that too
- Online, Chipotle-like setting
- Consumers see menus with either
  - Zero plant-based modern alternatives (PMA)
  - one (Sofritas)
  - or two (Sofritas & 'Chickn'itas)
- Outcome is whether they fill a taco with meat or not

Taking a bite out of meat, or just giving fresh veggies the boot? Plant-based meats did not reduce meat purchasing in a randomized controlled menu intervention

Jessica E. Hope[1*], Seth A. Green[1], Jacob R. Peacock[1], Maya B. Mathur[1]

Once again we find tiny effects

Figure 3: Taco Filling Choice by Treatment Arm



- ~1 pp. less meat per PMA
- Each new PMA cuts back on other plant-based options

None of these interventions is actively making the case for plant-based options

- Nothing seeks to improve their appeal to the senses/tastes
- Instead we get interventions that tell people, 95% of your classmates think the veggie burger is tasty!
- or 60% of your peer group is vegetarian!
  - That's nice! But do I care?
  - Per Dannenberg et al., 2024, the answer seems to be no
  - in fact, men order more meat when their choices are being observed, even if you tell them a majority of their peers are vegetarian

Let's make the case for plant-based options

- Telling people meat is bad/wrong will probably produce small effects: ~1-2 pp
- Telling people that more and more of their peers are becoming vegetarian: what happens when they see that most people still eat meat?
- IMHO the frontier is making plant-based options delicious and touting their health benefits
- Address beliefs about protein head-on!
- Thanks :) Questions?